

DJING AT 40 IS A CHOICE YOU MAKE AT 25.

The working manual for the DJ's body — pre-gig,
in the booth, post-set, and across the week.

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HOW TO USE THIS

This is a working manual, not a lecture. Screenshot the pages you need. Print the timeline on page 3.
Every recommendation is a science-backed baseline — adjust to your body, your gigs, your life.
Not medical advice. Talk to a doctor about anything specific to your health.

SECTION 01

THE 48-HOUR PRE-GIG PROTOCOL.

The ramp-up. Most of what decides how your set feels is set in the 48 hours before you play. Not the day of. The 48 hours before.

48 HOURS BEFORE

- Sleep target: 7.5–8 hours, aligned with your normal window.
- Start hydration ramp — an extra 500ml water across the day.
- Cut alcohol completely from this point until after the set.
- One easy movement session: 30 min walk, stretch, or light gym. No hard training.

24 HOURS BEFORE

- Meal template: protein + slow carbs + electrolytes at every meal.
- Afternoon nap window if you can: 20–90 minutes, not longer.
- Screen exposure: dim brightness after sunset, blue light off after 9 PM.
- Caffeine cutoff: 2 PM if you're playing a night set. Non-negotiable.

6 HOURS BEFORE

- Pre-gig meal: 60–80g complex carbs + 30g protein + vegetables. Nothing new, nothing spicy.
- Water: 500ml at meal, then 250ml per hour until the set starts.
- One 3–5 min stretch routine focused on lower back, hips, calves.
- Footwear check — cushioned soles, broken in, not new.

1 HOUR BEFORE

- Final light snack if hungry: banana, handful of nuts, or a small oat bar.
- Fill and label two water bottles — one for the booth, one backup.
- Warm-up: 60 seconds of shoulder rolls, 60 seconds of calf raises, 60 seconds of neck stretches.
- Mental cue: this is a shift. Pace yourself accordingly.

SECTION 02

IN THE BOOTH. HOUR BY HOUR.

Print this. Stick it above the setup. The protocol that keeps your last hour as sharp as your first.

HOURL 1 0–60 MIN

- Sip 250ml water in the first 30 minutes. Don't wait for thirst.
- Two 15-second calf raises during any breakdown longer than 30 sec.
- Body scan: shoulders down, jaw loose, knees soft.

HOURL 2 60–120 MIN

- Second 250ml water — before the end of the hour, not after.
- Weight-shift pattern: full weight on left foot for 30 sec, then right, alternating every 3–5 minutes.
- Roll shoulders 3× backward during any long build.

HOURL 3 120–180 MIN

- Hydration checkpoint: you should be at 750ml minimum. Electrolyte pinch if the room is hot.
- Micro-stretch during any breakdown 45+ seconds: reach up, then side-bend both ways.
- Check jaw tension — unclench.

HOURL 4 180–240 MIN

- This is where most DJs quietly lose form. Fight it.
- One 60-second stretch during any long breakdown — calves, hip flexors, upper back.
- Third 250ml water. This is not optional.

HOURL 5 240–300 MIN

- The endurance zone. Reduce water slightly — 150–200ml — to avoid over-hydration.
- Micro-movement between every third mix. Even 10 seconds counts.
- Box breathing: 4 seconds in, 4 hold, 4 out, 4 hold. During any 30-sec breakdown.

HOURL 6 300–360 MIN

- Final push. Stay upright, shoulders back.
- Last 200ml water 15 min before end — not right at the end.
- Mental prep: the crash is coming in ~60 min. Plan the wind-down now.

SECTION 03

THE 12-HOUR POST-SET PROTOCOL.

The window nobody teaches. What you do in the first 12 hours after finishing decides how your Tuesday feels.

FIRST 30 MINUTES · THE COOLDOWN

- No alcohol. No caffeine. Both make the crash worse.
- 500ml water + electrolytes (a sachet or a pinch of salt + squeeze of lemon).
- Sit down for 5 minutes. Let the adrenaline start dropping.
- If you can eat: a small carb + protein snack (banana + nut butter, or a small sandwich).

FIRST 2 HOURS · THE WIND-DOWN

- Reduce light exposure — dim everything, sunglasses if you're outside.
- Keep sipping water. Small amounts, often.
- Don't scroll socials in bright mode — use dark mode or don't.
- Warm shower helps signal the body it's done working.

SLEEP WINDOW · THE ACTUAL RECOVERY

- Cool room (18–20°C). Dark. Phone on airplane mode.
- Melatonin exists and is used by shift workers globally. Ask your doctor — not a listicle.
- Sleep as long as your body wants. Don't set an alarm unless you have to.

FIRST MORNING AFTER · THE RESET

- Recovery meal: eggs, oats, protein, vegetables, water. Real food.
- Movement: 20–30 min walk in daylight. This resets circadian rhythm faster than any pill.
- Coffee is fine now — keep it to one cup, before noon.

REMAINING 12 HOURS · THE FULL RECOVERY DAY

- Zero hard training today. Light movement only.
- Two proper meals + snacks. Keep protein and hydration high.
- In bed by 10–11 PM. Sleep as long as your body allows.

SECTION 04

THE 7-DAY GIG-WEEK STRUCTURE.

Zoom out. Not one gig — the whole week around it. Assumes a Saturday night set. Shift the days if yours is different.

MON RECOVERY

Light day. 20-min walk. Full sleep. Extra hydration. Zero hard training. Body is still repairing from Saturday.

TUE REBUILD

Return to normal food and sleep. Light cardio ok. Cortisol should be back to baseline by evening.

WED BUILD

Full training day if you train. Best day of the week for hard work. Body is fully recovered.

THU MAINTAIN

Moderate training. Start ramping hydration up. Cut alcohol from tonight.

FRI PRE-LOAD

48-hour pre-gig protocol starts. Sleep target 7.5–8h. One easy movement session. No hard training.

SAT GIG DAY

24-hour + 6-hour + 1-hour protocols. Nap in the afternoon if possible. Execute the in-booth protocol from Page 3.

SUN RECOVERY

12-hour post-set protocol. Real food. Daylight walk. Early bed. This is not optional — it's part of the job.

IF YOU PLAY 2+ GIGS A WEEK

The recovery window shrinks. You'll need to be stricter, not more relaxed. Prioritise: hydration on schedule (non-negotiable), 48-hour alcohol cutoff before every gig, and a full recovery day after each set. Two gigs back-to-back on Fri+Sat means Sunday is a full write-off day, not a working day. Plan the week around that reality — don't fight it.

SECTION 05

THE MOVEMENT LIBRARY.

Five moves you can do in the booth without breaking the set. Screenshot this page.

01 THE CALF RESET

15 seconds. Rise onto your toes, hold 3 seconds, lower slowly. Repeat 3×. Prevents blood pooling in lower legs. Invisible behind the booth.

02 THE BOOTH SHOULDER ROLL

10 seconds. Roll shoulders backward 3× slowly during any long build. Opens up upper back after long mixing posture.

03 THE WEIGHT-SHIFT SEQUENCE

Ongoing. Shift full weight to one leg for 30 sec, then the other. Alternate every 3–5 minutes across the whole set. Reduces lower-back load without any visible movement.

04 THE HYDRATION PAUSE

2 seconds. During any breakdown, reach for water bottle, sip, place back. Build it into your natural rhythm so it doesn't feel like a break.

05 THE CORTISOL-DOWN BREATH

60 seconds. Box breathing: 4 in, 4 hold, 4 out, 4 hold. Do this during any breakdown 45+ sec long. Preps the post-set crash by activating parasympathetic nervous system early.

FURTHER READING · THE SCIENCE

• Frontiers in Public Health (2026)

Long-term night shift work and cardiometabolic health — mechanisms + intervention strategies.

• PMC 11899833

Modified Cortisol Circadian Rhythm: The Hidden Toll of Night-Shift Work.

• Garcia, Läubli & Martin (2015, 2018)

Long-term muscle fatigue after standing work — the peer-reviewed baseline on standing-fatigue physiology.

• Antle et al. (2013)

Development of discomfort and vascular and muscular changes during prolonged standing tasks.

PROTECT THE BODY THAT CARRIES ALL OF IT.

One gig doesn't hurt you. Ten years of unprotected gigs does. Start with one move this week. Add another the week after.

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

This is a working manual based on peer-reviewed shift-worker and ergonomics research. Consult a doctor for anything specific to your